A second debate—covering foreign affairs—was scheduled in two weeks in Kansas City, so I had a second chance; another disastrous performance could send Nancy and me packing, headed back to the ranch for good.

I decided I wasn't going to do as much cramming as I had done before the first debate, and it's a good thing I didn't, because something happened at the second debate that I think wouldn't have happened if I had been overtrained. One of the reporters on the panel asked me whether age was going to be a handicap or other factor in the campaign. I suppose it was a polite way of raising the fact that I was seventy-three; and the question alluded, by inference, to my troubles at the previous debate.

My answer to the question just popped off the top of my head. I'd never anticipated it, nor had I thought in advance what my answer might be to such a question. I just said, "I am not going to exploit for political purposes my opponent's youth and inexperience."

Well, the crowd roared and the television cameras flashed a shot of Mondale laughing. I'm sure that if I had been as stuffed with as many facts and figures as I was before the first debate, I wouldn't have been able to come up with that line; your mind just isn't flexible enough if it's saturated with facts because you've been preparing for an examination.

According to the count of some reporters, Mondale took twenty-two tough personal potshots at me during the debate in Kansas City, most of which questioned my capabilities for leadership. But the majority of people watching the debate that night, the reporters wrote, remembered that one line more than any other: I guess my response had satisfied them that I wasn't senile. After my goofs during the previous debate, I think it's possible I sewed up reelection with those fourteen words; I'm not sure. But the incident reminded me once again of how